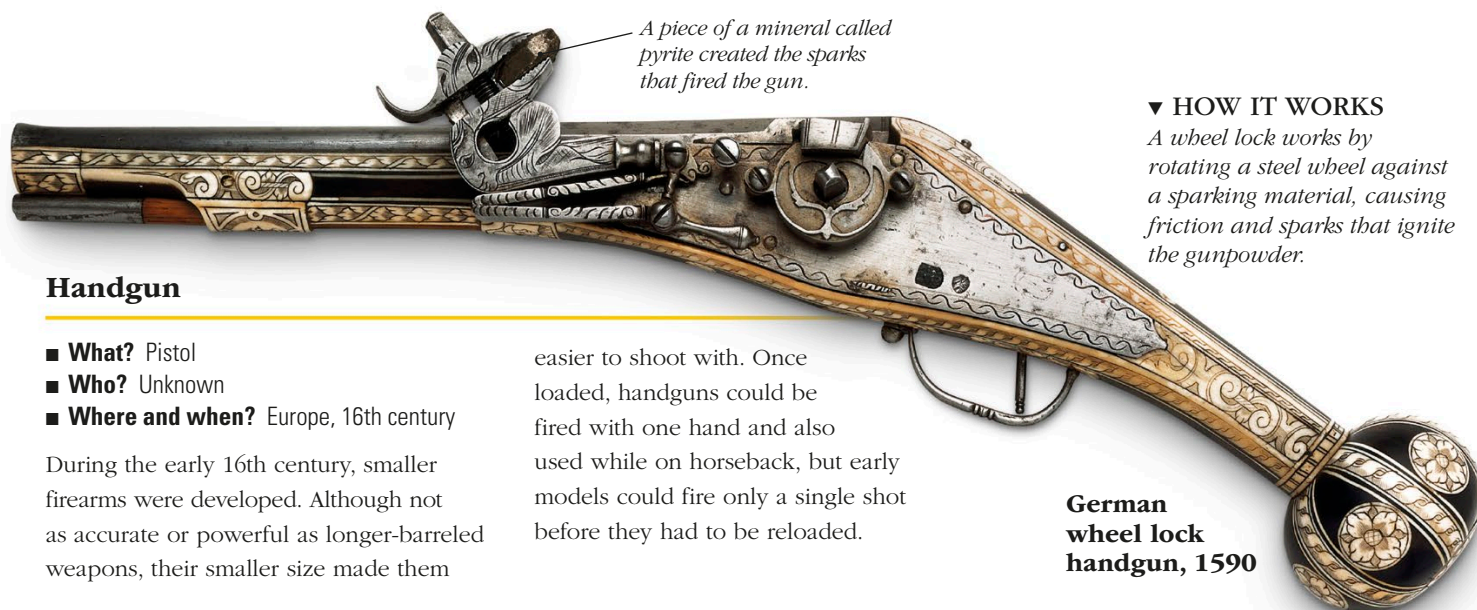




▼ HOW IT WORKS

A wheel lock works by rotating a steel wheel against a sparking material, causing friction and sparks that ignite the gunpowder.

German wheel lock handgun, 1590

Handgun

- **What?** Pistol
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** Europe, 16th century

During the early 16th century, smaller firearms were developed. Although not as accurate or powerful as longer-barreled weapons, their smaller size made them

easier to shoot with. Once loaded, handguns could be fired with one hand and also used while on horseback, but early models could fire only a single shot before they had to be reloaded.



Long barrel

Flintlock firearm

- **What?** Musket with flintlock mechanism
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** Northern Europe, c. 1550

The flintlock mechanism was used in a type of gun called a musket. When the trigger was pulled, it struck a flint against a piece of steel, creating a spark that ignited the gunpowder. Some muskets were “rifled,” which meant that grooves were marked on the inside of the barrel to make the bullet spin and travel toward its target with greater accuracy.



Baker rifle, a type of flintlock gun, 1802–1837

Percussion cap

- **What?** Firearm with percussion cap
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** US/northern Europe, c. 1820

The percussion cap was a small metal cup filled with an explosive mixture of chemicals called “fulminate” and sealed with foil. When the trigger of the gun

was pulled, it moved a part called the “hammer” that struck the percussion cap, sparking off the gunpowder charge and firing the ammunition.

▼ FIRING AWAY

Dressed as soldiers in the American Civil War of the 1860s, these riflemen are firing percussion-cap weapons.

Percussion-cap mechanism

